THE INCUMBENT

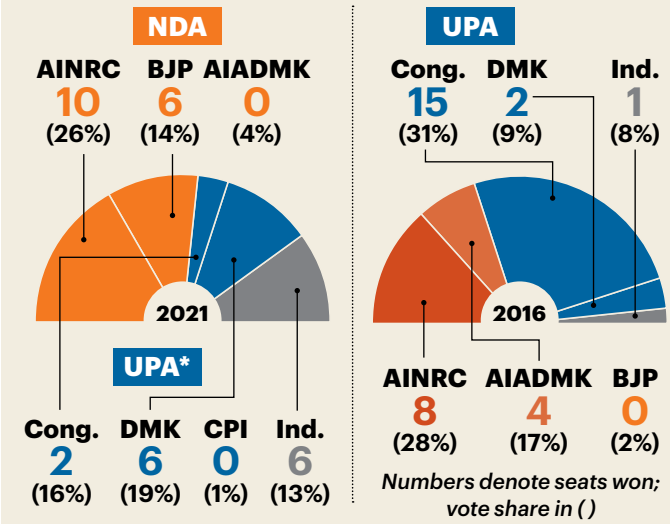
N. Rangasamy, 75, AINRC, *Chief Minister, Puducherry*

KEY STRATEGIES

- Four parties—the AINRC, BJP, AIADMK and LJK—are contesting under the banner of the NDA, led by Rangasamy, whose appeal among voters has endured for decades after varied stints in political office
- The alliance is pitching itself as the stable alternative to Congress's infighting, bolstered by the BJP's control of the central government, and local presence
- An emphasis on pensions, subsidies and direct benefit schemes can sway the UT's significant number of government employees

PAST RECORD

Total seats: **30**

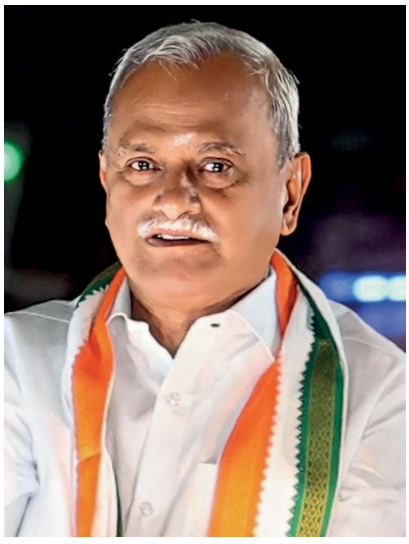


Numbers denote seats won; vote share in ( )

**Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi and an independent candidate also contested under UPA but won no seats and a negligible vote share*

THE CHALLENGER

V. Vaithilingam, 75, Congress, *party state chief, ex-CM*



KEY STRATEGIES

- The Congress-DMK alliance is arguing against the incumbent regime by targeting the UT's infrastructure and unemployment situation
- It pitches itself as a stable option that combines the Congress's legacy base and the DMK's cadre strength, with the bonus of an experienced administrator in Vaithilingam

The Opposition, if anything, has had a rougher time. The Congress-DMK arrangement, with the former contesting 16 seats and the latter 13, was finalised only at the last minute, and the process left bruises. The Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) walked out altogether, citing seat disputes, and will contest three seats on its own. Inside the Congress, the mood turned fractious when former chief minister V. Narayanasamy was denied a ticket on the final day of nominations. Six rebel Congress candidates were suspended for filing nominations in seats meant for alliance partners, but five are running the race anyway. In a 30-seat assembly, such leakage is hard to absorb—the alliance needs them to lose badly.

The most-watched contest will likely be in Thattanchavady, where Rangasamy faces Congress state president V. Vaithilingam. The latter is also a sitting Lok Sabha MP, and a man who has himself been chief minister twice. It is, in effect, a contest between two versions of what Puducherry's political leadership should look like: Rangasamy's brand of hands-on, accessible governance versus Vaithilingam's claim to experience and institutional credibility. The dilemma between a reset and business-as-usual is also something that actor Vijay's TVK is banking on, focusing its energies in all 30 seats on young voters fed up of the old faces. In constituencies where the winning margin in the 2021 assembly election was narrow, even a modest TVK vote share could scramble the outcome.

The most-watched contest will be between Rangasamy, who stands for accessible governance, and Vaithilingam, who relies on experience and credibility

"This is advantage Rangasamy," explains Mudhalvan, a Puducherry-based political analyst. "The Congress has been losing ground on more counts than one. The party has failed to build effective leadership, and lacks leaders that will help with caste votes. The party also did not treat VCK, a trusted ally in Tamil Nadu, with respect." With all players in this three-way contest seeking to woo the dominant Vanniyars, the more marginalised OBCs as well as Dalits, besides the Muslim and Christian minorities, the outcome will depend on who can convince voters that a frosty alliance doesn't always mature into a brittle government. ■